



The Nokia Windows 8 tablet

Apple's iOS is the mobile platform used by the iPad, the same for the iPhone and iPod touch. On the iPad, iOS is extremely similar to the way it works on the iPhone, with certain changes to take advantage of the tablet's larger 9.7-inch screen. The built-in iPod app on the iPad, for instance, has an extra side menu for additional navigation options that wouldn't fit on the iPhone's screen. Generally speaking, the great strength of Apple's iOS is that it is very intuitive, and there is a wide selection of iPad apps that you can buy right on the tablet from the Apple App store. More than 200,000 iPad specific apps currently and all these work uniformly well with very few exceptions.

Google's mobile OS, Android, is a more complicated story though. Besides having your choice of hardware from several manufacturers, there are a few different iterations of Android floating around on tablets currently. The latest version, Android 4.0 (Ice Cream Sandwich), which combines two platforms and takes them forward, Gingerbread the OS used for phones and Honeycomb the one used for tablets. It is now a single operating system for all Android devices and was released back in November, but we've only seen it on a couple of tablets so far. Most manufacturers have made the move to Honeycomb, but some are still making tablets with previous versions of Android that are meant for phones with smaller screens. Amazon with the Kindle Fire, and Barnes and Noble, with its Nook Tablet, each use its own highly customized version of Gingerbread, which, for the most part, in the cases of these smaller 7-inch tablets, is successful.

But if you are going for the larger screen tablets, you want to make sure you are getting Android 4.0. The good news is that most Honeycomb tablets will be